

Korea Daily Brief

Thursday, September 17, 2026

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RE: Kim Yo Jong: DPRK nuclear status 'absolute' · Cho-Rubio talks on investment & Hormuz · Bloomberg: NK workers making Russian drones · Fed hikes 25bp

KOSPI
6,715.41
▼ -0.0%

USD/KRW
1,383.98
▲ +1.5%

BRENT
\$99.47
▼ -6.0%

BOK RATE
2.50%
Sep 2026

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Kim Yo Jong declared North Korea's nuclear weapons state status 'absolute' and 'irreversible' in a KCNA statement rejecting the IAEA's 70th General Conference calls for denuclearization.
- 2 ROK Foreign Minister Cho Hyun departed for Washington to meet Secretary of State Rubio on Friday, with the agenda covering the US-Korea investment deal, Hormuz navigation, and North Korea.
- 3 Bloomberg reported Russia is employing North Korean workers to manufacture drones under fake visas, with a separate Yonhap report citing up to 100,000 NK workers sent abroad overall.

• TOP STORIES

DPRK

Kim Yo Jong declares DPRK nuclear status 'absolute,' rejects IAEA denuclearization calls

Kim Yo Jong rejected international calls for denuclearization at the IAEA's 70th General Conference, stating in a KCNA statement that North Korea's status as a nuclear weapons state was 'absolute' and could not be reversed. The statement also warned that increased US-ROK cooperation on countering WMD could trigger a nuclear response from Pyongyang. The declaration arrives nine days after Kim Jong Un's last confirmed public appearance and two days after KCNA claimed a multi-type nuclear firepower drill on September 12.

NK News · Reuters · Sep 17

US-KOREA

FM Cho Hyun departs for Washington; Rubio talks to cover investment deal, Hormuz, and North Korea

ROK Foreign Minister **Cho Hyun** left Seoul for Washington on Thursday for meetings with Secretary of State Marco Rubio scheduled for Friday. The agenda covers implementation of the US-Korea investment deal, South Korea's potential role in Hormuz navigation security, and North Korea policy. The foreign ministry separately

convened a headquarters-and-mission videoconference on crude oil supply and alternative sea routes amid Red Sea and Hormuz instability.

Yonhap English · 뉴스시스 · Sep 17

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

Russia employing North Korean workers to manufacture drones under fraudulent visas

Bloomberg reported that Russia is using North Korean workers to produce drones under fake visas, a new layer of the labor-weapons nexus documented since 2023. A separate Yonhap report cited assessments putting total North Korean workers deployed abroad at up to *100,000*, with some confirmed involved in Russian drone production. The Bloomberg finding adds a technology-transfer dimension to the existing munitions-shipping channel: workers embedded in Russian defense production facilities, not merely exported labor.

Bloomberg · Yonhap English · Sep 17

• OVERNIGHT

DPRK	Former US DPRK envoy Biegun: Trump may propose Kim summit after APEC, possibly in Pyongyang · NK News Biegun says Pyongyang venue 'would not be a surprise at all.'
BUSINESS	US Federal Reserve raises benchmark rate by 25bp — first hike since July 2023 · Yonhap English BOK now under pressure to follow; US-Korea rate gap widens.
US-KOREA	Prosecutors indict former President Yoon Suk-yeol over wife's luxury bag case · Yonhap English Separate indictment from ongoing insurrection trial proceedings.
DPRK	North Korean auxiliary boat sinks off South Korea's east coast near Pohang · Yonhap English ROK authorities responding; vessel origin and crew status under investigation.
TRILATERAL	US weighs purchasing warships from Japan and South Korea to counter China — Nikkei · Nikkei Korea Part of broader US naval capacity-building push in Indo-Pacific.
DPRK	Satellite imagery shows North Korea upgrading urban combat training facilities near Pyongyang · NKPro Both bases previously used for special forces training before Russia deployment.

• STAT OF THE DAY

100,000

North Korean workers reportedly sent abroad by Pyongyang

A Yonhap report citing a broader assessment puts the total of North Korean workers deployed overseas at approximately 100,000, with some confirmed involved in Russian drone production.

PYONGYANG WATCH · KCNA

KIM JONG UN

WATCH FLAG

- No appearance (9d since last)

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

1. Kim Yo Jong denounces IAEA's denuclearization meeting; declares nuclear status 'absolute'

Kim Yo Jong rejected IAEA calls for denuclearization at the agency's 70th General Conference, declaring the DPRK's nuclear weapons state status irreversible. — KCNA (Reuters)

2. North Korea warns US-ROK WMD cooperation could trigger nuclear response

A DPRK Ministry of National Defense spokesperson stated via KCNA that US-ROK joint activities to counter WMD could provoke a DPRK nuclear response. — NK News

3. Kim Jong Un letter to Putin pledging to strengthen cooperation and declaring Russia's war victory **KIM**

Kim Jong Un sent Putin a message pledging to strengthen cooperation and declaring Russia's victory in its war — continuing the 'sacred war' rhetoric documented since Sep 15. — KCNA (Kim stmt)

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Kim Yo Jong · Vice Department Director, Korean Workers' Party

Issued KCNA statement declaring DPRK's nuclear weapons state status 'absolute' and dismissing IAEA denuclearization calls at the agency's 70th General Conference.

Bottom line: Kim Yo Jong's 'absolute' nuclear status declaration and the concurrent WMD-response threat signal a hardening of DPRK posture as FM Cho heads to Washington; Kim Jong Un is absent from state media for nine days — watch Punggye-ri and any KCNA escalation tied to the Sep 19 Asian Games opening or the post-anniversary window.

● ROK GOVERNMENT

President + Ministries · Thursday, September 17, 2026

외교부 · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

FM Cho departs for Washington; Rubio talks on investment, Hormuz, and North Korea

FM Cho Hyun

Foreign Minister Cho Hyun left Seoul Thursday for Washington to meet Secretary Rubio on Friday. Agenda covers the US-Korea investment deal, South Korea's potential Hormuz navigation role, and North Korea policy.

Primary [Yonhap EN ↗](#)

외교부 · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

MOFA convenes headquarters-and-mission videoconference on Hormuz/Red Sea energy supply

윤영기 아중동국 심의관

MOFA's Africa-Middle East Bureau convened 11 overseas missions to assess crude oil, LNG, and naphtha supply chain risks amid Hormuz and Red Sea instability; embassies directed to leverage local government and corporate networks for supply risk monitoring.

Primary [뉴스시스 ↗](#)

통일부 · MINISTRY OF UNIFICATION

Unification Minister: no inter-Korean dialogue possible if denuclearization is precondition

Unification Minister Chung Dong-young

Minister Chung stated that framing denuclearization as a prerequisite for dialogue is incompatible with the Lee government's engagement approach. The government also confirmed it has no plans to pursue additional legal action over North Korean destruction of South Korean-owned property.

Primary [Yonhap EN ↗](#)

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Kim Seung-won **NOMINATED**

Justice Minister

The National Assembly judiciary committee adopted the confirmation hearing report for justice minister nominee Kim Seung-won on Thursday under Democratic Party leadership; presidential approval (재가) had not been issued as of Thursday evening. A forged online notice falsely claimed Lee had already signed the appointment order, prompting a Blue House alert.

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Assembly passes confirmation motion for Supreme Court justice nominee; confirmation hearing reports adopted for justice and defense minister nominees

Plenary / Judiciary Committee

The National Assembly plenary passed the confirmation motion for the Supreme Court justice nominee Thursday. The judiciary committee separately adopted the hearing report for the justice minister nominee (Kim Seung-won), and a combined committee adopted the report for the defense minister nominee. Formal presidential appointment had not been gazetted as of Thursday evening per [뉴스시스](#).

Steel and aluminium remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge lapsed July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff rate. Section 301 is now the primary prospective vehicle for any new measure against South Korea.

TARIFFS

EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now the primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates still in force.

WATCH THIS DATE

next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

SECTOR RATES

Steel & Aluminum	SECTION 232	50%
Copper	SECTION 232	50%
Automobiles & Auto Parts	SECTION 232	15%
Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives	SECTION 232	15%
Semiconductors (advanced logic)	SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002)	25%
Pharmaceuticals	SECTION 232	up to 15%
Civil Aircraft & Parts	US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION	0%
Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources	ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST	0%

NEW THIS WEEK

US trade commission institutes probe into Samsung, Apple, Google following patent infringement claims New deal

The USITC instituted a Section 337 investigation into Samsung, Apple, and Google on patent infringement allegations; a finding of violation can result in import exclusion orders on affected Korean devices.

['US INTERNATIONAL TRADE COMMISSION', 'SAMSUNG ELECTRONICS', 'APPLE', 'GOOGLE'] · YONHAP ENGLISH

FULL TRADE REFERENCE →

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

TECH · YONHAP ENGLISH

Doosan to invest 970 billion won to ramp up CCL production capacity

Doosan Group will invest 970 billion won to expand copper-clad laminate production, a substrate critical for advanced AI and high-bandwidth memory packaging. The investment aligns with accelerating demand driven by AI infrastructure buildout.

Doosan

FINANCE · YONHAP ENGLISH

Foreign investors turn net buyers of South Korean assets in August — BOK data

Foreign investors shifted to net buyers of South Korean financial assets in August, according to Bank of Korea data, reversing a prior selling trend. The reversal coincides with expectations of KOSPI resilience even as the Fed resumes its hiking cycle.

TECH · YONHAP ENGLISH

Samsung Galaxy Z Fold 8 domestic sales accelerate following Apple's first foldable smartphone reveal

Domestic sales of Samsung's Galaxy Z Fold 8 increased after Apple unveiled its first foldable device, with Samsung benefiting from consumer comparison searches; the competitive dynamic is tracked separately under the USITC patent investigation now underway.

Samsung Electronics

Apple

• NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

JAPAN-KOREA · JAPAN-HISTORY · YONHAP ENGLISH

South Korea files official complaint at Asian Games over Japan highlighting Japanese warlord in ceremony

The top South Korean sports body filed an official complaint after the Asian Games opening ceremony highlighted imagery tied to a Japanese warlord; the protest reopens historical grievances in the bilateral relationship despite the two defense ministers' recent call for stable cooperation.

RUSSIA-KOREA · RUSSIA-LABOR · YONHAP ENGLISH

Up to 100,000 North Korean workers sent abroad; some involved in Russian drone production

A report citing broader assessments puts North Korean overseas worker deployments at up to 100,000, with a subset now confirmed involved in Russian drone manufacturing under fake visas per Bloomberg. The scale — if confirmed — exceeds previous public estimates and represents the largest sanctioned labor deployment in the bilateral NK-Russia axis.

CHINA-KOREA · CHINA-DIPLOMATIC · YONHAP ENGLISH

ROK-Central Asia summit: leaders agree to deepen cooperation in critical minerals and energy

President Lee Jae-myung and leaders of five Central Asian states concluded the first Korea-Central Asia leaders summit in Seoul, agreeing to deepen cooperation on critical minerals, energy, and supply chains; MOTIE signed industrial and supply chain cooperation MoUs with Central Asian industry ministers.

• PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

38%

▼ 2 pts vs Sep 4

Gallup Korea · week of 2026-09-11

42% since Aug 25-27 ↓ 38% across 3 readings

RULING
Democratic

39%

OPPOSITION
People Power

25%

INDEPENDENTS

26%

Gallup Korea Spotlight August 25-27, 2026

Presidential Security and Defense Approval: Lee Jae-myung's approval stood at 42% in the Aug 25-27 Gallup poll (lowest since inauguration), with disapproval crossing 50% for the first time; respondents prioritized OPCON transfer, denuclearization, and inter-Korean military balance as key security concerns.

Discourse: Korea Times editorial (Sep 17) notes Lee's approval has fallen into the low 30s in some polls; a JoongAng Daily editorial flags Democratic Party discussions over extending the fiscal stimulus program through next year.

• UPCOMING

Oct
1

ROK Armed Forces Day (국군의 날)

Also the anniversary of the ROK-US Mutual Defense Treaty, signed in Washington on 1 October 1953. Recent years have brought a parade through central Seoul and new systems shown publicly; alliance statements from both capitals usually land the same day.

Oct
3

National Foundation Day (개천절)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct
9

Hangul Day (한글날)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct
10

Workers' Party founding day

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

• THE WIRE

ROK-US troops conduct annual explosive ordnance disposal drills

Joint EOD exercises part of standing combined training program; USFK commander separately opened Combined Warfighting Forum this week.

US-KOREA · YONHAP ENGLISH

South Korea and France stage joint air drills to enhance interoperability

ROK Air Force conducted joint aerial exercise with French counterparts; Air Force chief also traveled to Czech Republic for Europe's largest defense show.

US-KOREA · YONHAP ENGLISH

Hanwha Systems and UAE's EDGE Group to team up on integrated air defense network

Partnership targets integrated air defense system development; Hanwha is also expanding ground unmanned systems for South Korea's next-generation defense concept.

• ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

Commander UNC/CFC/USFK @CDRUNCCFCUSFK

“Honored to open the Combined Warfighting Forum yesterday. Our adversaries are not deterred by concepts on paper, but by integrated warfighting capability they can see, measure, and cannot discount.”

Context: Statement at the Combined Warfighting Forum; consistent with USFK commander's Sep 16 public reaffirmation of the conditions-based OPCON transfer and integrated combined forces posture.

[View on X →](#)

ROK MSIT Minister @msitminister

“AMD will establish Asia's first AI Excellence Research Center in Korea this year, to co-develop research with our universities and research institutions and expand joint research in new drugs, climate, energy, manufacturing, and physical AI.”

Context: Cooperation follows the minister's July San Francisco meeting with AMD CEO Lisa Su; AMD's entry adds CPU-GPU-NPU integration to Korea's AI infrastructure strategy alongside NVIDIA, Anthropic, and Brookfield already committed.

[View on X →](#)

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



Lee Jae-myung
ROK President

“Rather than waiting for a perfect measure, acting on what is possible now is the better decision. That is why the National Policy Coordination Council decided yesterday to introduce abortion medication in phases.”

Analyst: Posted on X Thursday and reported by 동아일보 and 뉴시스; the Constitutional Court ruled abortion restrictions unconstitutional in 2019 with a legislative deadline of end-2020 that was missed, leaving a seven-year gap.

[Source →](#)

COMMENTARY

FOREIGN POLICY

The Next Trump-Kim Summit Could Be About North Korea's Future Ruler

The piece argues that the diplomatic logic of a prospective Trump-Kim meeting has shifted from arms-control bargaining to succession politics: Kim Jong Un would gain international legitimization of his chosen heir while

Trump gains a visible foreign policy event. Former envoy Biegun's Thursday comments about a possible Pyongyang-hosted summit provide the news hook.

CSIS

U.S.-Korea Trade and Investment Deal | The Capital Cable #142

The CSIS Capital Cable episode addresses the current state of US-Korea trade deal implementation following Section 122 expiry and the shift to Section 301 as the primary tariff authority vehicle. The episode is timed to FM Cho's Washington visit.

• SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

3 of 11 sites at elevated or alert status

NK NEWS / NK PRO · SEP 16-17 — DPRK URBAN COMBAT TRAINING FACILITY UPGRADES

North Korea upgrading urban combat training facilities at military base near Pyongyang

NK Pro satellite imagery analysis shows North Korea upgrading urban combat training facilities at a large military base near the capital; urban drills also appeared to take place recently at a separate base. Both bases were previously used for special forces training connected to the deployment of over 10,000 soldiers to Russia. The findings are consistent with continued post-deployment reconstitution and capability development at DPRK special operations units.

NK News / NK Pro ↗

ELEVATED ▲

Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

IAEA confirmed North Korea built a new uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon (Reuters/CNN, Sep 9-10, 2026), assessed capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually (조선일보). Russia dismissed the IAEA report at the Vienna session, citing lack of access. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running. Thermal signatures consistent with increased plutonium/HEU production.
imagery as of 2026-09-10

ALERT ▲

Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind. NK News reporting confirms North Korea remains closed to private car travel via the bridge; crossings are limited to organized bus tours per the Association of Tour Operators of Russia (ATOR). NBC News analysis (Sep 15) frames the bridge alongside the near-complete Sinuiju-Dandong crossing as dual infrastructure bets by Pyongyang.
imagery as of 2026-09-15

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

ACTIVITY ▲

Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)

Sep 11, 2026: 38 North satellite imagery analysis shows the new North Korea-China border crossing (new Yalu River Bridge) appears close to opening.
Mar 12, 2026: Cross-border passenger train service resumed between Sinuiju and Dandong after COVID-era suspension. NBC News analysis (Sep 15) cites both crossings as signals of North Korea deepening ties with both Russia and China simultaneously.

imagery as of 2026-09-15

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail.

imagery as of 2026-09-08

7 other monitored sites: no new imagery in the last 30 days · oldest report 2025-05.

CSIS

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